



Honouring the Aces: The Hindu CEO L.V. Navaneeth presented the Sportstar Aces Sportsman of the Year (Team Sports) award to Hardik Singh (Olympic bronze medallist), and Sportstar Editor Ayon Sengupta presented the Sportstar Aces Sportswoman of the Year (Individual Sport) award to Sift Kaur Samra (Asian Games gold medallist). R. V. MOORTHY

Eyeing the Paris gold

Hockey and shooting have been India's most successful sports in the Olympics. With five months to go for the Paris Games, anticipation regarding medal prospects in these two disciplines is palpable.

"The team is 110 per cent ready to win gold," said Hardik Singh, midfielder and vice-captain of the Indian men's hockey team, during the panel titled 'Eyeing the Paris Gold.'

The men's team secured the Paris Games quota after winning the Asian Games crown in Hangzhou. Hardik, who was named the 2023 FIH Player of the Year, underlined the importance of the continental event.

"People often say that Asian Games hockey is easy, but they forget that since the sport made its debut in the tournament, Indian men have won only four golds. Our main aim was to win gold and qualify. We do have the advantage of

time as many European nations or Australia have to take part in qualifiers, but as our coach says, the Olympic cycle is not 'a single day', it is 'every day.'"

Unlike hockey, earning a quota in shooting does not automatically guarantee a place at the Olympics since the athletes also need to show consistency in multiple national selection trials. Sift Kaur Samra, finished fifth at the Baku World Championships last year to win a quota in the women's 50m rifle three-position category. She also won Asian Games gold in the same event with a world record score.

"Everyone is young, and everyone wants to perform well. Shooters did an excellent job at the Asian Games, and everyone has family support. Unlike before, we also have enough equipment. I don't think we have pressure. Everyone knows they have to work on their technique, and we will do it. Pressure shows that we are humans, but we also know how to control it," she said.

